commercial and industrial users pay more than the cost while all other categories, such as domestic consumers or civic utilities, are subsidised. Besides, the skewed structure of tariffs—where power costs are increased to offset the low recovery of fixed costs—has driven high-paying consumers to source cheaper power from open exchanges. Finally, there is a need to accurately assess power consumption by metering all connections, including agri pumpsets, even if these are not being charged. "If they bring in these reforms, then it should not be such a big deal to give it to the poor. I think it's fair to say that the farming community and the poor deserve to get electricity at subsidised rates," says Gurucharan.

But it's not as though all the subsidy schemes will be implemented straightaway. "There will be some conditionalities...and then they may spread it over the five years. That's how it works in practice," explains Ravindra. In a press conference in Bengaluru on May 2, former Union finance minister P. Chidambaram pointed out that Karnataka was already providing certain units of free electricity and foodgrains. "If you look at the incremental cost of these five guarantees, it will be about Rs 30,000-35,000 crore," he said, explaining that it would add up to about 10 per cent of the state's budget size of around Rs 3.09 lakh crore. "In my humble view, 10 per cent of the budget being devoted to essential welfare schemes is absolutely necessary," he added.

Welfare schemes apart, the Siddaramaiah government will have other pressing matters on its plate. Top among these will be addressing regional disparities that have stymied growth in the northern regions. The outgoing BJP regime had pursued a 'Beyond Bengaluru' initiative to push investments in the digital economy in Tier-2 towns. In its manifesto, the Congress has promised to reserve Rs 5,000 crore each year for infrastructure development in the backward Kalyana Karnataka region and a separate Rs 5,000 crore grant to establish a Kittur Karnataka Development Board. In addition to this, it will have to urgently fix Bengaluru, the state's cash cow. The capital city's infrastructure and civic woes are well-known; Bengaluru's last masterplan expired in 2015 and a new one is still a work in progress after eight years. "If Bangalore is an IT hub, it is because the Congress governments made it so," says Siddaramaiah. That makes it a doubly important task for the new CM.

Other challenges abound: with corruption endemic in the system, the new government will have to plug the leaks and spruce up the administration. In Siddaramaiah's earlier tenure, he had controversially defanged the state's Lokayukta—which had been a much-feared institution at its zenith a decade ago—and instead set up an Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB), which functioned under the government. In August 2022, the Karnataka High Court, ruling on a batch of public interest litigations, abolished the ACB and restored the Lokayukta's original powers to investigate cases. The result was evident: while the ACB had not registered any criminal cases against ministers, MPs, MLAs or MLCs over a period of six years, the Lokayukta, within six months of its revival, had made its first high-profile arrest this February by trapping the son of a BJP MLA while allegedly receiving a bribe.

Though a seasoned administrator, Siddaramaiah had in his first term come in for criticism from various quarters, especially the dominant Vokkaliga and Lingayat communities, which chafed at being sidelined. Hence, while his government successfully implemented a bouquet of welfare schemes, it was eventually this resentment among the powerful caste groups that hurt the Congress in the 2018 election. This time around, with the party winning the support of every major community, the new government will have to proceed with more tact in administration and politically—especially so in navigating tricky issues such as revisiting the reservation policy and dusting off the contentious caste census report prepared during Siddaramaiah's previous term.

SIDDARAMAIAH SAYS HE WILL WORK TO REDUCE CORRUPTION, BUT IN HIS EARLIER TENURE, HE HAD CONTROVERSIALLY DEFANGED THE STATE'S LOKAYUKTA, A MUCH-FEARED INSTITUTION AT ITS ZENITH

Then, of course, there is the delicate task of cabinet formation. Siddaramaiah and DKS have worked together before, when the latter was minister for energy during his first term as CM (2013-18). But even back then, the two didn't hit it off. In fact, DKS, though by then a senior partyman who had been minister twice in previous Congress governments, was kept out of the cabinet for nearly eight months before the high command stepped in. But if DKS had been eyeing the top job this time around, there were several other senior Congressmen too who considered themselves eligible—among them, M.B. Patil and G. Parameshwara were open about their aspirations. The key task now for Siddaramaiah, and the party, will be in picking ministers from this pool of seniors, while also keeping a mindful eye on giving appropriate representation to each community.

With the Lok Sabha polls in a year's time, Karnataka is a crucial state for the Congress as well as the BJP. In 2019, the latter had swept 25 of the state's 28 Lok Sabha seats while the Congress retained only one. The sole winner, incidentally, was D.K. Suresh, KPCC president DKS's brother. The onus thus will be on DKS to keep the momentum going. "He will continue as PCC president till the parliamentary elections are over," said AICC general secretary K.C. Venugopal on May 18 while announcing the new CM and deputy CM. Both Siddaramaiah and DKS, he said, were "big assets of the Congress party" in the state. Now in power, the duo will have to deliver on key promises while keeping the party unit fighting fit for the next big test. ■